

Chapter 32-9

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The next morning, Liang Shi drove Xu Qingzhu to work. She had also made simple sandwiches for Xu Qingzhu to eat in the car before resting.

Additionally, since she got up early, she made two lunch boxes for noon.

One for herself and one for Xu Qingzhu to take.

She drove Xu Qingzhu to the company building before returning to her own company.

This scene happened to be witnessed by Sally, who walked over holding an iced Americano, "Blanche, we're here working overtime until we cry, while you're being sweet with your wife. We're so miserable."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I just saw your wife," Sally said. "She looks pretty good. How about it? Did you tell her about dinner? Does she have time? If not, we can go to your place. I haven't found a house yet and I'm staying at a hotel. If it weren't for considering you two are newlyweds, I would have moved in long ago."

Staying up all night drawing designs didn't interfere with Sally's chatterbox nature—she chirped like a little sparrow in her ear.

Xu Qingzhu immediately said, "I already told her. This Friday evening, I'm treating."

"Why are you treating? OMG." Sally made an exaggerated surprised expression. "If you're treating, why call her? As your friend, shouldn't she be treating? Haven't you ever treated her friends?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...Actually, no."

However, Xu Qingzhu didn't argue about this issue and directly shifted the topic to work, "Last night I found the problem with Cherry's design draft. Quickly eat some breakfast, let's have a meeting."

Only then did she remember, "Where's Cherry?"

"She went home to shower," Sally said. "That clean freak—she'll die if she doesn't shower twice a day."

Xu Qingzhu: "...No wonder you two can't live together."

Sally: "..."

Sally was someone who could go two days without showering, but Lin Luoxi, as a severe germaphobe, had to shower twice a day.

"So you know how painful it was when we were together, right?" Sally held her forehead. "I can't even bear to recall it."

Lin Luoxi's voice rang out coolly from the doorway, "How truly wronged you were."

Sally: "..."

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Friday evening, Xu Qingzhu booked dinner at a Chinese restaurant.

Because Sally truly loved Chinese cuisine. Once in college during a game of truth or dare, while she was drunk, Lin Luoxi asked her: "If you had to leave China one day, what would you miss most?"

Without thinking, Sally blurted out, "Soup dumplings¹."

This nearly made Lin Luoxi want to bite her to death.

Afterward, Sally seriously explained to Lin Luoxi, "I really feel sorry for every foreign compatriot who hasn't eaten Chinese food. They've really missed out on too many good things."

During her years studying in China, Sally had almost checked off cuisines from all regions, and whenever she talked about them, she could recite them like family treasures.

The three of them came together after work. When they arrived, Liang Shi was already sitting at the table waiting. Upon seeing Xu Qingzhu, she stood up, looking at her with a smile full of affection in her eyes.

"Wow," Sally exclaimed. "Blanche, your wife is really beautiful."

"Our Zhu isn't bad either, okay?" Lin Luoxi immediately said. "Put away that infatuated face."

"Yes, I think my wife is more beautiful," Liang Shi said.

"Let me introduce everyone," Xu Qingzhu interrupted their conversation and made introductions for both sides. Sally was talkative and, although meeting for the first time, wasn't shy at all.

Lin Luoxi had met Liang Shi at the wedding before, but the impression hadn't been good then.

After they all sat down, Liang Shi poured tea for everyone, her movements unhurried and graceful in every step.

Sally could pick up on any topic she chatted about.

To converse with Liang Shi, Sally kept speaking in her broken Chinese until she couldn't say something and anxiously blurted out a sentence in English, which Liang Shi immediately answered in English.

Sally was delighted, "Your English pronunciation sounds so good. Are you really not a singer? I think you must sing well."

Liang Shi smiled and answered, "Does a wild singer who hasn't released any albums count as a singer?"

"Then we can go to KTV later," Sally extended an invitation.

Liang Shi didn't refuse.

Lin Luoxi, observing from the side, looked at all this with confusion, then whispered to Xu Qingzhu, "Is this your wife-controlling magic? Why is she completely different from four months ago?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

What did this have to do with her?

She wanted to know too!

"What's different?" Xu Qingzhu wanted to get some answers from others.

"Her eyes," Lin Luoxi had seen countless people—her mother was an excellent diplomat, so she was very good at reading people. "Four months ago, there was no light in her eyes at all, and she seemed very fake. My god, I was wondering then why you would fall for someone like that. She was completely superficial²."

Xu Qingzhu: "...And now?"

Lin Luoxi took a sip of tea and said leisurely, "Like tea—the more you taste it, the more flavorful it becomes. She gives a very comfortable feeling."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

In the evening, Sally insisted on drinking with Liang Shi. Liang Shi said her alcohol tolerance wasn't bad, so Xu Qingzhu believed her.

But unexpectedly, after three glasses of wine, Liang Shi's face turned red.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Why did she believe Liang Shi at that time?

However, she still loyally accompanied Sally in drinking. After drinking, they went to KTV, where Liang Shi's singing was indeed very good.

Not only was her English pronunciation very standard, but her Cantonese³ pronunciation was also very standard.

When it was time to leave, Lin Luoxi supported Sally, who could barely stand, while Xu Qingzhu supported the drunk but quiet and obedient Liang Shi.

On the way back, Liang Shi was very quiet throughout, completely unlike someone who would usually cause trouble for Xu Qingzhu when drunk.

It wasn't until they got home that Liang Shi opened her eyes. But those eyes were hazy, and she smiled at Xu Qingzhu, saying very gently, "You're so beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu felt her ears heat up, then helped her into the room, threw her onto the bed, and went to pour her a glass of water.

When she returned, Liang Shi was lying on the bed giggling foolishly.

Xu Qingzhu asked her, "Who are you?"

"Liang Shi," Liang Shi's voice carried a hazy drunkenness. "Don't you remember me?"

She sat up with an obedient posture, like a five-year-old child.

Xu Qingzhu touched her head and coaxed, "I remember."

"Where were you from originally?" Xu Qingzhu asked again, with a hint of coaxing.

"Originally..." Liang Shi repeated, then frowned. "Originally... where was I from originally?"

She sighed, her voice very aggrieved, "Sister, I can't remember."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She gave up and said, "Then just go to sleep."

"Okay," Liang Shi said in a very cute childish voice. "I'm going to sleep now. You should sleep well too."

"Mm-hmm, okay," Xu Qingzhu said perfunctorily, wanting to help her drink water, but Liang Shi didn't cooperate and instead smiled brilliantly.

She said, "Life will definitely get better, because we will definitely have lots of love."

Xu Qingzhu's water glass suddenly fell to the ground, and she was completely stunned.

Footnotes:

¹ Soup dumplings: Xiaolongbao (小笼包), a type of steamed dumpling filled with broth

² Superficial: Literally "embroidered pillow" (绣花枕头), a Chinese idiom meaning something that looks good on the outside but lacks substance

³ Cantonese: A Chinese dialect spoken primarily in Hong Kong and Guangdong province